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No one knew. They came.
Exploring photo-elicitation in societal development

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Abstract: Citizen dialogues strive for inclusivity but often exclude marginalized groups. New participatory and creativity-based approaches are needed to be evaluated and become a part of the skillset repertoire for public officials to foster an inclusive dialogue. This paper reflects on photo-based conversations as a dialogic method for societal development and inclusion. The results show that the method provides possibilities to creatively involve participants, strengthen relationships and open a space for diverse narratives between different actors in society. However, the challenges of internal exclusion, lack of strategies for impact, and the need to build competence in handling conflicting stories, without depoliticizing discussions, must be addressed. This research contributes to design methods as drivers of public sector innovation by discussing how creative, participatory approaches can support inclusive dialogue in society. The results presented is part of a four-year research project aiming to enhance coordination between diverse actors and organizations in everyday landscapes.

Keywords co-design; citizen dialogues; photo-based conversations; living environments

1. Introduction

It is an evening in the autumn of 2024, and a backyard in the Big City is shrouded in penetrating darkness. Surrounding this yard is a kaleidoscope of activities: museums, high schools, municipal offices, coworking spaces, a restaurant, and a large tech company a bit further away. Nearby, the central station hums with the activity of trains and buses. During the day, the mixture of institutions fills the interiors with life: students rushing to lessons, museum visitors exploring exhibits, employees gathering over coffee, and guests discussing future projects. The yard has a private owner but operates as a place for the practical patchwork of daily life for many actors. Students, office workers and museum visitors pass regularly through what is colloquially called the "Piss Tunnel" often to walk from the train and bus station to the entrance of their work or school. The name stems from the tunnel's nocturnal visitors, who arrive after the commuters have departed, finding the dark alley with its nooks a convenient restroom.

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In the Small Village at the countryside, three hours are spent at the lawn surrounding an often-used community driven cultural building in almost complete silence. Not seeing anyone except dog walkers once every half hour. The place remains quiet, with only a few cars driving by.

The study presented here, takes departure in those two pilot-places and is a part of a research project that particularly aims to foster societal development practices in everyday landscapes where coordination capacity between different actors and organisations is needed to create a change in the living environment. The study reflects on the results of the first two exploratory workshop that inquires photo-elicited interviews as a possible dialogic practice for different actors. It reframes photo-elicitation from a qualitative research technique to a dialogic design method for critical placemaking in private/public-sector contexts. Drawing on the two empirical cases, we explore both the democratic potential and the limitations of the method with departure in the question: How does photo-elicitation function as a dialogic design method for critical placemaking among diverse actors, and what opportunities and challenges emerge?

2. Background

According to a regional report from 2021 in the region that is home to the two pilot places, a higher percentage of residents aged 16–84 report lacking trust compared to the national average. Children in economically vulnerable households is 2% above the national average, ranging from 8% to 19% across municipalities. Many residents report poor perceived health, and mental health issues among youth in grades 7, 9, and high school are rising, with psychological stress linked to a more pessimistic outlook on the future.

The two pilot places in our study, are examples of everyday landscapes that constitute the living environment for citizens but tend to fall in between in the planning and development processes. They are still important places for many people that spends their time there. Place A in the Big City, is an often-crowded yard, privately owned by a property manager. The city has over 150 000 inhabitants. The yard has an attractive placement in the city centre and has a Tobin's Q value over 1. A value above 1, indicates that investing in new assets is likely to be profitable. The site has many stakeholders with interests in it; it is used as a rear entrance to a cultural centre, serves as a parking area for cars, and functions as a hub that facilitates all deliveries to the surrounding schools and offices. Pilot Place B, the outdoor environment around a cultural centre, run by an association and offers many activities, such as a café and craft evenings. Other local associations also use the centre for meetings. The outdoor land is partly owned by a forest company, the municipality and the culture centre association. The small village, with around 3000 inhabitants in the wider area around it, has a Tobin's Q under 1. When it comes to land and real estate, it means that the market value of the property is lower than the cost of for example replacing or reconstructing an equivalent property.

Seemingly different, what these places have in common is that they fall in between as spaces for creating a well-designed living environment. This is partly because there are so many different owners and stakeholders, which in turn creates uncertainty about who can and may express their experience of the place. There are no established forums for conversation

and development, and it is unclear who has the right to act there. These are places that invite negotiation in anticipation of change.

3. Theoretical framework

The Danish urban planner and architect Jan Gehl, in his book *Life Between Buildings: Using Public Space* (2006), studied how people behave in public environments. Gehl argues that public spaces should be designed with people in mind and respond to the needs of its inhabitants. *Placemaking* is about creating and improving public spaces to make them more vibrant, functional, and appealing for both visitors and residents (Gehl, 2006).

The concept *critical placemaking* has emerged in design and social research as a further development of placemaking, where the focus shifts from place design as an aesthetic or functional activity to a reflexive, situated and political practice (Allen & Queen, 2018). From a design research perspective, critical placemaking is about considering place development as a process where design functions as a mediating tool to explore relationships between people, environments and power structures and where designers can evolve existing human-centred design (HCD) methodologies. This makes it possible to make visible and problematize the complex connections that shape our built environments, social territories, governing policies and economic flows (Allen & Queen, 2018; Forlano, 2016; Huybrechts, 2018).

In the project presented here, the complex connections are relevant working with everyday landscapes that are neither a focus for new investments nor have clear development strategies. In this context, the evaluation of the method of photo-elicitation for societal development can be seen as an example of exploring design methods for critical placemaking, where the process not only seeks solutions but also opens up for conversations about social territories, power and policies.

3.1 Relationship densification

In practice, with the aim of advancing societal development, new strategic functions that take the relational aspect in societal development in consideration are increasingly common. These functions navigate the complex landscape of change and often operate without a clear mandate, moving among various actors, underscoring the importance of relationships and an understanding of local needs and conditions (Döös, 2003; Tyrstrup, 2007).

Ferrazzi (2020) highlights interpersonal relationships as a resource for responding to and adapting to societal change, and promotes approaches designed to bypass rigid silo structures. The term relationship densification has evolved and refers to the process of strengthening and increasing the number of relationships between individuals and organizations to promote collaboration and network development (Tyrstrup et al., 2022). In practice, as the ambition to contribute to societal development grows, professionals are now seeking new design-oriented practices and strategic functions that take relational aspects into account. This shift also opens up for an interest to evaluate participatory methods and the possibilities that emerge as we move beyond the idea that it is only designers who use design methods for inclusion.

3.2 Inclusion in societal development

Citizen dialogue initiatives aim to create forums and platforms that gather diverse opinions from various societal groups. A prevailing criticism is still that marginalized communities often remain underrepresented (Ferlander & Karlberg, 2023; Tahvilzadeh, 2023; Wiberg, 2018). These challenges within citizen dialogues are related to the field of deliberative democracy and the concepts of inclusive democracy. Young (2002) is distinguishing between external and internal exclusion within a democracy. External exclusion refers to formal barriers which can prevent participation and influence in decision-making processes. Internal exclusion refers to the real constraints in pre-decision-making discussions and meetings aimed for equal participation. The constraints can appear as restrictions of which perspectives or opinions are allowed, or more implicit constraints through agenda control, hence who is heard, what opinions are taken in account and so on. One focus Young emphasizes is that there is a lack of deliberative approach in the meetings and participants and explores what inclusive democratic communication entails to better include marginalized groups. Participation is also uneven, due to the "costs" associated with attending. Engaging in these dialogues requires genuine interest, time, and the ability to participate on the specified day, at the designated time and place (Brady et al., 1995; Verba et al., 1995). Furthermore, understanding the language used is crucial, as most dialogues center around verbal communication (Tahvilzadeh, 2023).

Additionally, there are insufficient structures in place to manage the feedback provided by the public during these dialogues and the documentation of citizen dialogues tends to be limited to information that aligns with the meeting's agenda, leaving out valuable insights and are not transparent (Eriksson et al., 2022). The promotion of citizen dialogues tends to highlight their positive attributes, portraying them as straightforward initiatives, what might be termed "happy talk" (Ahmed & Åsard, 2017). The concept of happy talk presents these dialogues as uncomplicated and apolitical while simultaneously framed as sustainable solutions to societal issues (ibid.). By controlling the narrative to ensure predictability, the dialogues can become depoliticized, stripping them of the nuanced discussions that are essential for meaningful engagement (Wiberg, 2018).

From a design research perspective, this tension calls for a reconsideration of how participation and dialogue are understood and practiced. Gatt and Ingold (2013) suggest that in a world continuously shaped by the activities of its inhabitants, design should be understood not primarily as a pursuit of innovation but as an ongoing, improvisational process that evolves in relation to how people live and dwell. In this light, citizen dialogues could be reimagined not as managed events with predetermined outcomes, but as ongoing, improvisational processes of co-creation embedded in everyday life. Thus, the aim of early citizen involvement in societal planning aligns with participatory design, emphasizing collaboration and diverse input for inclusive, sustainable solutions bringing together designers, users, and other actors to co-create environments reflecting community needs (Björgvinsson et al., 2012; Simonsen & Robertson, 2013).

In design, workshops are often used to foster dialogue and collaboration, particularly in urban planning where interdisciplinary solutions address equity and sustainability (Sanders & Stappers, 2008). Low-fidelity prototypes, visual tools like photo-elicitation, mapping, and video diaries are said to enhance communication and inclusivity (Bratteteig & Wagner, 2016; Vaajakallio & Mattelmäki, 2014), providing insights into memory and future possibilities

(Brandt et al., 2012). Photo-elicitation prompts discussion and reveals personal narratives tied to place (Clark-Ibáñez, 2004; Mannay, 2010). Harper (2002) highlights its ability to transcend language barriers, offering richer insights into identity and social connections. Photos evoke layered experiences (Pink, 2015), foster collaborative interpretation, deepening understanding of cultural and sensory practices and incorporate for example, children's perspectives in participatory preschool redesigns (Schaeffer et al., 2018).

However, participatory design processes and methods also face challenges, including power imbalances, logistical constraints, and varying levels of stakeholder engagement (Robertson & Simonsen, 2012). Despite the availability of participatory approaches to societal development, significant gaps remain in how different actors and communities engage in inclusive and relational forms of collaboration. There is a need to explore methods that can bridge communicative, social, and institutional divides and make visible and problematize the complex connections that shape our built environments, social territories, governing policies and economic flows. Against this backdrop, this paper examines photo-elicitation as a potential practice for fostering dialogue between different actors in society.

4. Method

Following Gatt and Ingold's (2013) notion that design is an ongoing process of "dwelling" and improvisation rather than fixed innovation, the chosen participants for evaluation of the method of photo-elicitation were not external observers but active contributors to the continuous co-creation of place. Their hybrid roles, spanning creative, administrative, and civic domains, made them suited to unpack the complex social, political, and ecological relations embedded in the two local development processes.

The first workshops in the project thus involved actors from the project's two core groups, who were selected based on their professional engagement with design, development, architecture, or artistic issues, or as active users of the place. While this first workshops allowed for a focused exploration with actors in the core groups of the project, it is important to note that the perspectives of other community members were limited at this stage. Two workshops, about 2,5 hour long, were planned with the core groups for each pilot-place in the project. The participants were tree architects, three local artists, an author, a regional developer for health, a regional developer for art in public spaces that has workplace in one of the buildings surrounding place A, a PhD student in design, a researcher in design, that facilitated the workshop, and a stakeholder engaged in the communal cultural house in place B. Some participants were, in different ways, also actors and/or related to organisations in the places. This composition allowed the workshop to explore diverse perspectives on the method. How the photo-elicited workshops unfolded is described as a 4-step process below.

4.1 Introducing a question

The workshop began by posing a guiding question to focus the exploration, and to put emphasis on the participant's own story (see Figure 1). The facilitator explained that that the photography would serve as a medium to reflect on personal impressions, emphasizing that there were no right or wrong stories or photographs.

As Allen and Queen (2018) suggest, critical placemaking requires an approach that challenges what is seen, valued, or rendered invisible in the process of place-making. That's also why the starting point for the workshop was the rather open question: May you take some photos to capture your experience of this place?



Figure 1 The starting point for the workshop was the question: "May you take some photos to capture your experience of this place?" Participants were encouraged to explore and document their surroundings through their own lenses. Illustration: Andreea Strineholm

4.2 Capturing experiences through photography

The participants then embarked on a solo photo walk through the location. This step allowed participants the freedom to individually explore and document what resonated with them and emphasized the sensory and reflective dimensions of placemaking, allowing participants to engage with their surroundings through movement, perception, and embodied attention.

Pink (2015) argues that visual research should not be limited to representation but understood as a form of knowledge production grounded in local visual and sensory cultures.

By using the camera as both a research tool and a medium for reflection, participants were invited to notice textures, sounds, and atmospheres that might otherwise remain invisible in conventional planning dialogues (see Figure 2).



Figure 2 A solo photo-walk was the second step in the workshop. The solo photo-walk served as mediating act, and as an act inviting participants to critically reflect on spatial relations, material traces, and everyday practices that shape their experience of the place. Illustration: Andreea Strineholm.

4.3 Sharing images and narratives

After the photo-walk, participants reconvened to share their images and the stories behind them. Each person presented their photos in turn, describing what they saw, why it stood out to them, and how it connected to their experience of the place (see Figure 3). Still, it was possible for others to "borrow" the image and build on what was said or contradict it.

The facilitator encouraged active listening and dialogue by prompting participants with questions such as, "What do you see in the image?" and "Can you talk some more about…?" In addition, the facilitator reinforced the narrator's contributions with brief verbal acknowledgments like "yes" or "uhm," supporting a responsive and engaging conversational environment.

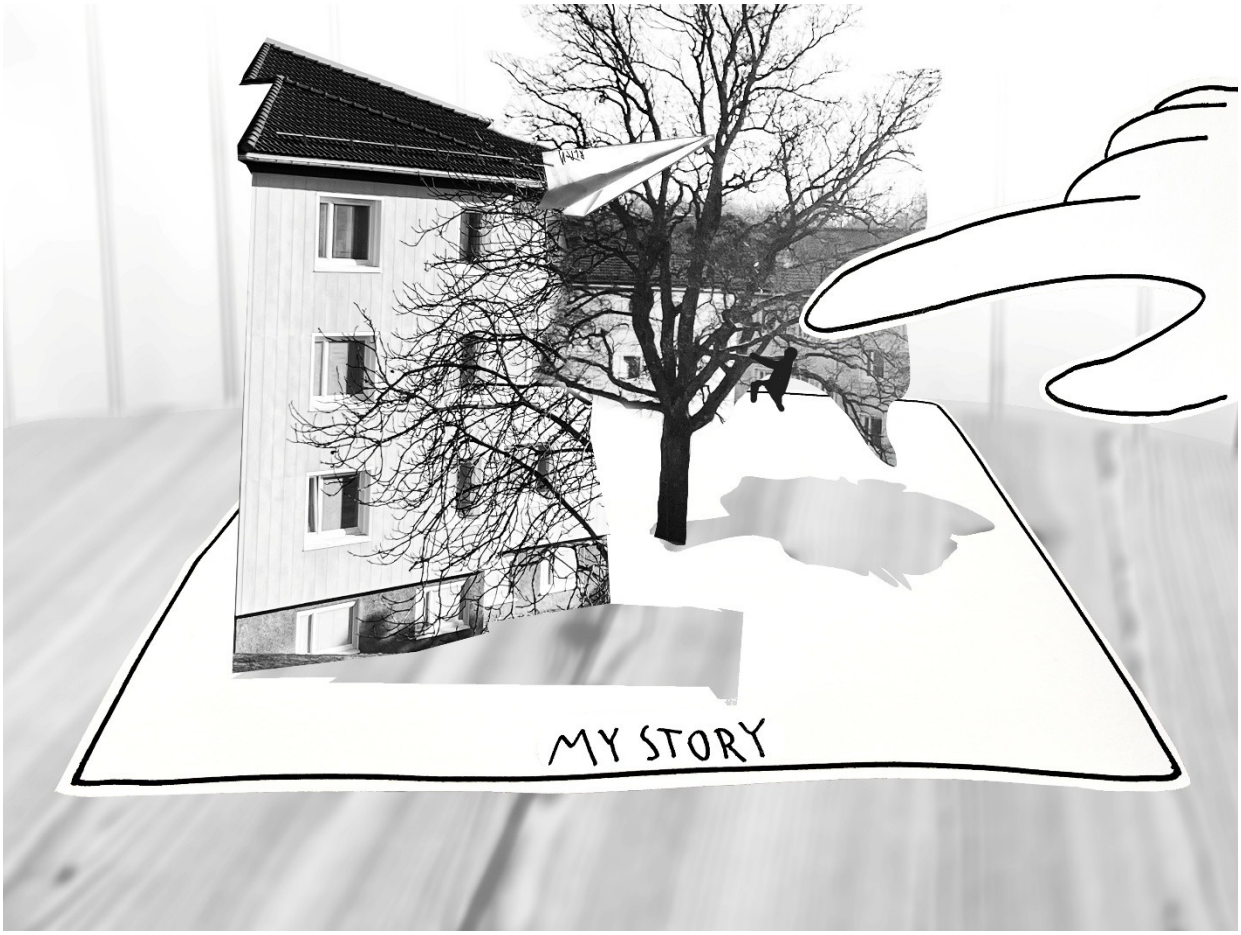


Figure 3 The participants shared their images and stories one after the other. In this stage, the workshop shifted slightly from individual reflection to collective dialogue. Each participant presented their photographs and narrated the experiences, memories, and emotions connected to them. Illustration: Andreea Strineholm.

4.4 Reflecting and synthesizing together

The session concluded with a group reflection on the shared images and stories (see Figure 4). The group reflection allowed participants to connect the workshop to broader societal and institutional contexts. The session ended with a reflection over the method from each participants perspective.

The photo-elicitation workshop was documented by field notes and participants' photographs. In addition, all participants also had time for individual reflection when completing a paper-based evaluation on opportunities and challenges of the method. These reflections served as a foundation for the concluding group discussion, where participants were able to elaborate on their experiences with the method.



Figure 4 In this stage, participants shared insights about collaboration, participation, and power in local development. The reflection connected personal experiences to broader societal contexts, turning dialogue into a moment of collective learning. Illustration: Andreea Strineholm.

4.5 Analysis

The photographs and the field notes from the discussions were transcribed from handwritten notes and paired with the respective images. The analytical process focused on photographs and conversations that were selected for deeper analysis based on two criteria: (1) images that represented recurring themes or motifs that several participants engaged with, for example when participants borrowed or referred to each other's images (see Section 5.1), and (2) images that generated visible emotional responses or extended discussion among participants. Such photographs can be understood as part of "evocative ethnography", which seeks to make space for and retain emotions and affect in ethnographic description and explanation (Skoggard & Waterston, 2015).

The initial coding of the field notes, photographs, and participants' narratives focused on identifying recurring topics, emotional reactions, and patterns of discussion emerging from the workshop material. The theoretical framework then guided the interpretation of the material, allowing the analysis to explore how the workshop method shaped participation, influence, and the framing of discussions.

The analysed material thus consisted of participants' photographs, transcribed field notes from the image-based discussions, and written evaluations reflecting on opportunities and challenges of the method.

5. Results

For this paper, four examples have been chosen to illustrate how these evocative images reveal the themes in the narratives of the situation on-site.

5.1 Inhospitality, passing through and opposite thoughts

During the photo-elicitation workshop in Place A, the image of the sky, a fragment of open space framed by dense, almost claustrophobic architecture, reoccurred in several participants' reflections. The recurring motif of the sky and light, described as "the light in the tunnel" by one of the architects evokes a sense of transience and movement, a place being "on the way," never arriving, never staying (see Figure 5). Another participant, a working in one of the buildings, associated the motif with its vertical framing with a movement away from the present place toward an imagined elsewhere and said that it is an outdoor space but perceived as extremely inhospitable, adding that: "It is something you must pass through. You have reached your goal when finally, inside.".



Figure 5 Place A, the image of the sky elicited a conversation about claustrophobia and freedom.

In this image, the place is perceived as something one passes through or showing a way out if the gaze is turned upwards. In this sense, the narratives reveal a tension central to how designed environments can simultaneously invite and repel, promise and deny belonging.

When the discussion continued about the question why it isn't possible to do much here to change the design of the place at ground level, the regional health developer reflects over the fact that it seems that the place gets stuck in regulations. One of the architects responds that it is "very common" [*in Swedish* "sjukt vanligt"] for places to be constrained by rules that prevent any improvements from being made.

The motif of a round yellow bench provided one of several opportunities for contrasting narratives to emerge (see Figure 6). The author reflecting on the motif of a yellow seat, described "the worn pause," valuing the rest stop as a gentle place among all the "shady corners" to pause. The PhD student in design then said, "I thought the opposite of what you said", interpreted the space differently, noting the interplay of old and new elements, the bright light through large windows, and a sense of openness despite the enclosing façades.

The divergent interpretations highlight how a single motif can evoke multiple, even opposing, narratives.



Figure 6 Picture of a post and a yellow seat, was a motif that elicited conversation from opposing stories.

5.2 Emotionally charged narratives, abandonment and care

During the photo-elicitation workshop in Place B, one photograph quickly acted as emotional catalysts, prompting participants to share emotionally charged narratives. Themes of felt grief, frustration, and exclusion surfaced in discussions, particularly around the image of a felled tree (Figure 7). The photo became a symbol of the community's perceived exclusion from decision-making processes, as captured in the word of one of the three participants' that was living in the village:

> "No one knew. They came. /…/ Rumors spread. No plan yet. /…/ They [the trees] were taken down due to the risk of falling branches. Then, pines were planted without communication. Several pines have died; some company was supposed to come and water them. They didn't. /…/ No dialogue. This is a strong image of power and contempt. It became difficult to move forward. Meetings with the municipality followed. Yet, reaching each other was hard. Words.

Another participant added that the municipality seemed to view the area as "unnecessary countryside", which created a sense of discomfort and a negative feeling about being from the village.



Figure 7 A tree taken down due to the risk of falling branches, or?

As participants reflected on the photographs, the conversation shifted to a deeper conversation about asymmetrical power relations and the fragility of trust between local actors and municipal authorities. Although the image of the tree stump became an emotional focal point in this workshop, several images revisited power relations and the themes of *abandonment* and *care.*

The image of the abandoned restaurant (see Figure 8), hidden among the trees in the village, represent another perspective of the recurring theme of *abandonment* and *care*/*not care* throughout the discussions. Places that have been left behind, forgotten infrastructures and emptied activities, yet still hold traces of life, memories, and potential. From the local artists perspective, these places often evoke a dual response: the impulse to "do something," to restore or repurpose, and at the same time a sense of sorrow for what has been lost. The tension between these emotions reflects a broader paradox, a kind of *Catch-22*: there is no economic basis to sustain such a place, but the absence of engagement further erodes its possibilities. In this way, the photograph does not merely document decay but opens up questions about value, care, and responsibility in regions where the renewal and abandonment coexist.

These narratives provided insight into how residents perceive care, neglect, and the political-influenced boundaries of community life.



Figure 8 An image that elicited conversations about of places that have been left behind in the village in the countryside.

5.3 Workshop reflection the use of photo-elicitation as a method for societal development

The workshop reflections revealed a wide range of perspectives on the use of photo-elicitation as a method for critical placemaking and dialogue in developing the everyday landscapes that has many actors and un-clear plans or mandates. The method allowed for diverse explorations of relationships between people, environments and power structures. Participants emphasized its accessibility and inclusivity but also questioned its legitimacy and

structure. It was described as fun and creative, a new way of speaking, and opening many perspectives. It gave openings to build on each other by borrow each other's images and keep thinking and talking based on what they had just heard.

One of the architects valued the method's ability to bring together diverse viewpoints and generate meaningful input in a short period of time. However, they warned that its open-ended nature might risk diverting attention from the broader strategic picture. The regional developer, working at the intersection of public health and urban planning, appreciated the possibility to contain opposite viewpoints of the discussions that emerged and saw the method as a strong entry point for dialogue. Yet, they questioned how the collected information would be used, analysed, and prioritized, and whether such qualitative material could influence formal planning processes.

One artist and the author in the workshops highlighted the relational and affective dimensions of the method. For the author, the session offered a valuable opportunity for professional exchange and learning, a chance to connect with colleagues, new concepts, and new ways of working. Yet, the method was described as somewhat "fluffy," evoking both curiosity and scepticism.

One artist emphasized how photography encouraged direct, inclusive engagement with the site, pointing to its accessibility as most people carry a mobile phone. At the same time, they cautioned against the risk of technological dependence, where the device itself frames and limits perception.

The regional developer for art appreciated the efficiency and inclusivity of photography as a tool but found it "provocative" to follow a pre-defined method. They questioned whether such a structured approach might constrain artistic exploration, suggesting that the method could be better suited for participants without artistic training. Similarly, the PhD student in design viewed the method as productive for generating metaphors and narratives but noted that its lack of clear contextual anchoring might be either a strength, by inviting openness, or a weakness by causing confusion.

For the local stakeholders, the method evoked personal memories and emotional responses, particularly of childhood and past community experiences. One of the artists that was also engaged in the community house in Place B described the workshop as fostering "real meetings," while another representative from the community expressed reluctance to include certain actors, such as municipal representatives, due to perceived power imbalances and mistrust.

5.4 Key findings

- **Multiple perspectives on place:** Photo-elicitation enabled participants to explore relationships between people, environments, and power structures in complex everyday landscapes with many actors and unclear mandates.
- **Accessible and engaging dialogue tool:** Participants highlighted the method as creative, inclusive, and easy to engage with (for most, but not for everyone), enabling participants to build on each other's images and perspectives in discussion.

- **Openness as both strength and challenge:** While the open-ended format encouraged diverse interpretations and metaphorical thinking, some participants experienced confusion or felt that the lack of structure risked losing the broader strategic perspective.
- **Uncertain translation to planning processes:** Participants questioned how the qualitative material generated through the workshops could be analysed, prioritised, and integrated into formal planning and decision-making.
- **Relational and affective qualities and political narratives:** The method fostered professional exchange, learning, and emotional engagement with place, although some perceived it as somewhat "fluffy." The images triggered strong and sometimes conflicting narratives about fear, exclusion, neglect, and care, revealing emotions and power relations that formal meetings can fail to capture.
- **Power dynamics and participation:** The workshops revealed both the potential for "real meetings" between actors and the persistence of mistrust and perceived power imbalances, particularly regarding the involvement of municipal representatives.

6. Discussion

While the method was acknowledged for its potential to foster engagement, creativity, and diverse perspectives, concerns about its structure, relevance, and integration into formal processes suggest the need for development. Thus, the discussion with theory will nuance the findings in relation to possible internal exclusion, limited impact and its potential to resist depoliticizing discussions.

6.1 Internal exclusion

Participants, such as one artist in the study, highlighted the accessibility of photography and its capacity to creatively engage people and give space to talk. The method was also seen as a possibility to engage many perspectives and people, give a sense of life, being a good starting point and create "real" meetings. This reflects participatory design principles (Simonsen & Robertson, 2013), emphasizing diverse actor involvement in shaping environments. Still, photo-elicited interviews present several challenges, particularly concerning internal exclusion, as highlighted by Young (2002) since it can marginalize individuals who lack access to photographic tools or the ability to express themselves visually or, on the other hand, those who works professionally with images and feel forced into a method. That the choice of method is set in beforehand, and participants feels forced into it goes against the relationality, equity, and participation intended through participatory design (Udoewa and Gress, 2021). Norms shape whose voices are heard and whose experiences are validated. Including underrepresented groups, such as individuals selling drugs in Place A, would be an example of a real attempt of relationship densification (Tyrstrup et al., 2022), that requires a norm critical approach that seeks to understand lived experiences and perspectives form various citizens. Facilitators play a crucial role here, not

as authoritative figures but as listeners who confirm and support participants' contributions (Ahmed & Åsard, 2017). The method provides an opportunity to plan for the integration of underrepresented groups (Ferlander & Karlberg, 2023; Tahvilzadeh, 2023; Wiberg, 2018), if it could take in consideration challenges concerning interest, time, and the ability to participate on the specified day and place (Brady et al., 1995; Verba et al., 1995) and influence on the method of choice (Udoewa and Gress, 2021).

6.2 Impact

Despite its inclusivity potential, photo-elicitation raises questions about how qualitative data can be legitimized and integrated into formal planning and policy-making processes. One of the architects valued the method's capacity to broaden perspectives and gather significant input in a short period time, still the issue of transparency in many citizen dialogues and insufficient tangible impact (Eriksson et al., 2022) is also valid for the method. For instance, the regional developer expressed concerns about whether decision-makers needed direct involvement. This reflects a broader debate on the method's democratic potential and the impact of qualitative data in informing decisions. There are insufficient structures in place to manage the feedback provided by the public during photo elicitation interviews.

6.3 Depoliticizing discussions

Power dynamics and agenda control present challenges and as Eriksson et al. (2022) note, citizen dialogues often lack transparency and filter out information that conflicts with predefined agendas. Furthermore, Ahmed and Åsard (2017) critique the framing of citizen dialogues, noting a tendency toward "happy talk," where tensions and political complexities are downplayed. A risk is to depoliticise discussions and reduce the transformative potential of the method. From a practical perspective, maintaining focus in photo-elicitation sessions can be difficult. For example, an architect in the study expressed concerns that the method might divert attention from the broader picture, while the PhD student noted that conversations often veered away. Photo-elicited interviews have a potential here, as they were performed in this study at least, by giving space for vulnerable and not just happy talk. In line with *critical placemaking* (Allen & Queen, 2018) the focus in the dialogue opens for a discussion about design not only as an aesthetic activity but a reflexive, situated and political practice. The unpredictability that was thus put forward as a challenge with the method by some of the participants, we argue could in fact ca be a strength in the method from a democratic and inclusive perspective, since it is then harder to control the narrative, and the dialogues can become less depoliticized and bring nuanced discussions which is essential for meaningful engagement (Wiberg, 2018).

6.4 Future work

The knowledge generated through these workshops was taken forward by participants in several ways. It led to the organization of additional workshops with various formats to augment inclusion at the respective sites, allowing local actors to continue the dialogue and further develop the ideas that had emerged with the local communities. The dialogues served as a foundation for art and architectural processes that began in 2026, where insights from the workshops informed ongoing spatial and landscape development work. At pilot place B, a local politician and a municipal official were invited to participate in a dialogue,

expanding the conversation to include vulnerable issues related to power, inclusion and governance. These continued processes and engagements will be documented and discussed in forthcoming publications from the project, which is still ongoing.

7. Conclusion

The results reinforce the view of photo-elicitation as a method with significant potential to promote participation, relationship densification, creativity, and democratic dialogue, particularly in contexts where coordination between diverse actors and organisations is essential. However, several challenges must be addressed to further develop photo-elicited interviews as an inclusive practice within societal planning and development.

First, the risk of internal exclusion calls for more flexible and adaptive formats that acknowledge participants' varying abilities, interests, and means of expression. Second, the lack of clear strategies for impact highlights the need to better connect qualitative, visually grounded insights with formal planning and decision-making structures. Third, when using the method, practitioners must cultivate competencies that enable openness toward conflicting stories and prevent the depoliticization of discussions, acknowledging tensions as productive elements of democratic dialogue rather than obstacles to consensus.

Photo-elicitation as a tool for inclusion in societal process (and if we extend the reasoning also Participatory design) can benefit from detailed insights in democratic theory (for example Young, 2002) which critically examines how participation is shaped by power, representation, and procedural conditions. These perspectives help nuance the concept of *participation*.

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